

## Chapter 33 Part 1

——Sister, will you be afraid?

——I'm not afraid, because I believe there are gods watching.

——Sister, you don't need to be afraid either. You're so cute and beautiful, the gods will protect you from the shadows.

"But sister, there are no gods in this world."

——There are, as long as we believe, they will exist.

"Sister, does it hurt?"

——It doesn't hurt, don't be afraid.

"Sister, please don't smile anymore, okay? They'll hit you."

——No, only when I smile will the gods see me.

——I believe life will definitely get better, because we will surely have lots of love.

——So I must smile, smile happily, smile freely, so the gods can see.

Distant conversations were forcibly dragged out from the depths of memory, and Xu Qingzhu's mind was like towering waves being stirred up.

The bedroom was terrifyingly quiet, with only Liang Shi's even breathing as she lay sleeping on the bed. The perfectly curved smile at the corner of her mouth instantly pulled Xu Qingzhu back to the spring of eighteen years ago.

That year, on her way home from school, she was dragged into a black car by some people who covered her eyes with black cloth strips.

The run-down van reeked of unpleasant odors. The vehicle constantly bumped and swayed, cotton strips were stuffed in her mouth, her teeth ached, her mouth hurt, and her tears soaked her clothes.

She was taken to a dilapidated chemical factory in the suburbs—rusty iron gates, windowless rooms that never saw daylight, and two vicious yellow dogs that barked incessantly.

The lights in the chemical factory were dim and yellow. A group of people gathered around a small table playing poker and drinking, speaking in a dialect she couldn't understand, laughing and cursing. In this large room, there were seven or eight little girls about her age. The one beside her wore a blue dress and had fair, tender skin.

While she was still at the age of losing baby teeth, that little girl already had a full set of neat, white teeth.

The little girl especially loved to smile. When she smiled, her eyes curved into crescents, and every time she smiled, the curve of her mouth was exactly the same, looking very healing.

This was Xu Qingzhu's first time experiencing such a thing. She was terrified and had been crying since being tied up and brought in. Her tears fell like broken pearls, and she cried until her eyes started to hurt. The little girl next to her handed her a lollipop and whispered, "Sister, don't cry anymore. We'll get out soon."

The little girl said, "My name is Liang Shi<sup>1</sup>. The 'liang' from 'pillar,' the 'shi' from 'suitable.' What about you?"

"My name is Xu Qingzhu."

"How old are you?"

"Five years old."

"I'm seven, so I'm older than you, which means I'll protect you."

"These people are after money. Once our moms and dads give them the money, they'll let us go," little Liang Shi said.

They stayed in that windowless room for a long time, eating the same food as the two yellow dogs every day.

Liang Shi kept saying someone would come to rescue them.

But one day, when Liang Shi was asleep, one of the kidnappers said, "The Liang family is so rich, yet they won't even pay five million to ransom their daughter. They even told us to get rid of her."

Xu Qingzhu kept hesitating about whether to tell Liang Shi about this, but she woke up shortly after the kidnapper said it.

With red eyes, she told Xu Qingzhu, "They're all lying. My mom and dad will definitely come save me."

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> Liang Shi: 梁适 - The name uses characters meaning "pillar/beam" and "suitable/appropriate"

## Chapter 33 Part 2

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That period of memory was too painful. For Xu Qingzhu, extracting those memories thread by thread was an extremely agonizing experience.

But she still remembered those words.

Over the years, it was those words that supported her through one difficult day after another.

It was the person in her memory who kept encouraging her, telling her not to be afraid.

So Xu Qingzhu often told herself: don't be afraid, everything will get better, we will surely have lots of love, and then we'll love others without reservation.

When Liang Shi initially said she wanted to marry her, she was overjoyed.

She thought she was marrying that sister from back then, that gentle sister who would always encourage her to live on and tell her not to be afraid.

But she never expected that while the memories hadn't changed, the person in those memories had long since become different, and had even forgotten the things that happened between them.

For a long time, Xu Qingzhu couldn't speak. She didn't know how to interact with people. Seeing big yellow dogs would trigger her stress disorder, seeing black cloth would trigger her stress disorder, and even entering rooms without windows would trigger her stress disorder. At that time, her doctor had said that if she continued like this, they could hypnotize her to erase that segment of memory.

Because it was too painful, she could lose those memories.

After they met again, Xu Qingzhu had always thought she had lost her memory and, through the passage of time, had become vastly different from before.

But now she would smile with the same curve as when she was little, and would say—life will definitely get better, because we will surely have lots of love.

The current her retained the same habits as when she was young. Was this Liang Shi?

Which personality of hers was this?

The water glass accidentally slipped from her hand and fell onto the carpet. The glass didn't break, but the water soaked the carpet.

Liang Shi was already curled up on the bed.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly pounced on the bed and grabbed her, "Liang Shi, tell me, who exactly are you right now?"

Liang Shi drowsily opened her eyes, her voice carrying a dreamy quality yet still retaining some childlike innocence, "I'm Liang Shi, sister~"

She frowned, her trailing tone almost swallowed, speaking in a light, soft, and coquettish manner, "I want to sleep."

"Tell me who you are first?" Xu Qingzhu asked, "Are you a second personality? Or are you not you, but someone else?"

"It's me." Liang Shi sighed, her eyes couldn't open at all, "It's always been me. What's wrong with you? Sister~ let me sleep, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Liang Shi leaned back, directly pulling Xu Qingzhu down with her.

Xu Qingzhu was only a few centimeters away from her. Her hand even fell from the collar opening directly onto her collarbone, and with a light slide of her fingers, she could feel her delicate skin.

An Alpha's skin would be slightly rougher, but Liang Shi was an exception.

Liang Shi's skin was like cream—white and smooth. Although not as white as Xu Qingzhu's, it was still outstanding among Alphas.

The warm yellow light cast the shadows of both figures in an ambiguous and dreamy way, carrying a hint of allure.

Their breaths intertwined. Liang Shi lightly licked her lips. Because she had drunk too much alcohol, her body needed to replenish moisture. Moreover, she had sung many songs with Sally at KTV, drinking alcohol while singing. At this moment, she urgently needed water, and her lips were already somewhat dry and cracked.

Unable to obtain moisture, she could only gently extend her tongue tip to lick her slightly dry and cracked lips. Her eyelashes, which were longer and more curled than most Alphas', now cast a layer of shadow under her eyelids. Xu Qingzhu was propped above her body, positioned against the light, blocking all the dazzling lamplight for her.

But she still slept restlessly.

Not knowing what she was thinking about.

Xu Qingzhu didn't dare to breathe until she couldn't hold it anymore and deeply exhaled.

Their breaths intertwined in an instant. Liang Shi suddenly opened her eyes slightly, hazily seeing a face, then smiled and turned over, directly causing Xu Qingzhu to fall to her side.

The bed was very soft, and Xu Qingzhu's body even bounced a bit. With her eyes closed, Liang Shi casually placed her arm down, hugging Xu Qingzhu just like hugging a doll, her long arm embracing her.

The close physical contact made Xu Qingzhu's heart beat rapidly. She felt her face flush and her mouth dry, and the scene of Liang Shi licking her lips kept appearing in her mind.

Whether it was because of drinking too much alcohol, her tongue was very red.

It was a vivid red color similar to roses.

She nestled in Liang Shi's embrace, not daring to move.

For a moment, her mind was blank.

Only after she was truly asleep did Xu Qingzhu close her eyes and breathe in lightly while in her embrace.

There was only the rich but not unpleasant smell of alcohol, which even covered the faint tea fragrance that she usually emitted.

Many years had passed since that incident, and with Liang Shi's previous behaviors, Xu Qingzhu had long since recognized reality.

The sister she once looked up to was long gone.

What remained now was just the soulless dandy Liang Shi.

But she never expected that she would lose control again because of those words.

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The next morning, Liang Shi was awakened by her alarm clock.

The soothing light music sounded like it was playing frantically right next to her ears, making her ears hurt. With her eyes closed, she habitually reached for the bedside table but didn't find it, instead sweeping down something cold.

A muffled thud sounded, startling her. Her head immediately moved to the edge of the bed to see what had fallen to the floor, and then—

"Poof—"

Another muffled sound.

This time it was her phone that fell.

No wonder she felt the ringtone was right next to her ear—it really was right next to her ear.

She picked up her phone from the floor and checked the time. It was already eight-thirty.

Oh no!

She was going to be late!

She practically "sat up in shock from her deathbed",<sup>1</sup> directly taking off her shirt to change, but then stood in the room dazed for two seconds and slapped her forehead.

She had forgotten—today was Saturday, no need to go to work.

She collapsed back onto the bed and picked up the water glass that had initially fallen to the floor.

She wasn't even wearing a shirt, just her undergarments.

Being young, even under the original's dissolute and decadent lifestyle, this body didn't have much excess fat.

Liang Shi felt her brain buzzing with pain. She lay back on the bed and began to recall how she had gotten home, but her mind only contained memory fragments that couldn't be completely pieced together into a coherent storyline.

Most of the memory fragments were from when she was in the room.

Xu Qingzhu was pressing down on her, so close they were almost touching.

Xu Qingzhu's hand was lying beside her, fingers gently caressing her lips, and she seemed to have... extended her tongue tip.

Her tongue tip lightly touched her fingertip, and after sensing the warmth, she wrapped around it like eating something, while Xu Qingzhu wiped her wet finger across her lips.

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What happened after that?

She had forgotten everything after that.

While recalling those fragments, Liang Shi's lower abdomen tightened.

Just from recalling, she could be aroused to such a degree, so last night...

Did the two of them end up having some kind of relationship?

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> "垂死病中驚坐起" - This is a reference to a famous line from classical Chinese poetry, describing someone suddenly sitting up in shock despite being deathly ill. It's often used humorously to describe being startled awake.

## Chapter 33 Part 3

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Liang Shi knocked her head, trying to remember more things, but no matter how much she knocked, her memory was cut off right there.

She couldn't even think of anything more.

Drinking really causes trouble.

Liang Shi kept wailing internally.

She lay there seemingly calm and collected, staring at the ceiling, but internally she was thinking: should she go and apologize?

However, she still had all her clothes on, so they probably didn't do anything, right?

If they had done something, shouldn't they be lying in the same bed?

But Xu Qingzhu wasn't there this morning.

Xu Qingzhu surely wouldn't help her put on clothes after doing it, would she?

She felt like Xu Qingzhu might slap her twice after doing it, rather than help her put on clothes.

In just a few minutes, Liang Shi's mind had already experienced a storm.

Her emotions had also gone through various changes, and then she chose to lie flat like a salted fish.

After all, it was something that happened last night. No matter how capable she was, she couldn't go back to the past.

So apart from lying flat like a salted fish, there was nothing else she could do.

Liang Shi went to take a shower and changed clothes before going to the living room.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't there, only the housekeeper was cleaning.

The housekeeper politely greeted Liang Shi, and Liang Shi nodded in return, asking, "Have you seen Xu Qingzhu?"

The housekeeper glanced upstairs, "Madam is resting upstairs."

"Good." Knowing Xu Qingzhu's whereabouts, Liang Shi felt a bit more at ease.

At worst, she would just have selective amnesia like Xu Qingzhu.

Although she didn't have complete memory loss, she could act.

Just let last night's events pass.

At the same time, Liang Shi mentally scorned the original's alcohol tolerance. If it had been her own body, she could have drunk twice as much as last night and still not gotten drunk to the point of memory loss.

With the original's alcohol tolerance, she still wanted to be a debauched libertine? She should just go home and sleep early.

Liang Shi pressed her temples and sat on the sofa. The housekeeper brought her a glass of honey water.

The honey water was sweet on the tongue, suppressing some of Liang Shi's restless emotions.

Xu Qingzhu didn't come downstairs all morning. Liang Shi even went to the back garden to exercise, and when she returned it was just time for lunch.

The housekeeper who was responsible for cleaning had already left. Since Liang Shi had instructed them not to cook for them, the villa became increasingly empty. Apart from the housekeeper coming to clean every morning, the rest of the time it was just her and Xu Qingzhu. She took ingredients from the refrigerator, thinking about whether to make Xu Qingzhu's portion.

After thinking for a long time, she decided to go upstairs and ask.

After all, she hadn't come out of her room all morning, so she might have lunch plans.

Liang Shi finally found an excuse to go upstairs, but her feet felt weak as she stepped on the stairs.

When she met Xu Qingzhu later, what should she say?

Even greeting each other might be troublesome.

Liang Shi was afraid her years of acting skills would be ruined at this moment.

She hesitated, then turned around and went downstairs.

Better not go.

Just wait for Xu Qingzhu to come down herself. As long as Xu Qingzhu didn't bring it up, she would pretend not to remember.

Right.

That's the plan.

Liang Shi returned to the kitchen, but while cutting vegetables she started thinking again. After struggling for a few minutes, she stepped on the stairs again.

But after walking a few steps, she returned to the kitchen again.

After doing this several times, Liang Shi was almost driving herself crazy.

Why did it feel like she really did something with her?



She stood at the kitchen counter, listlessly cutting vegetables. Her usually five-star chef-level knife skills became terrible today, chopping a cabbage into pieces with no texture at all.

A voice suddenly came from behind, "Are you planning to make dumplings?"

Liang Shi's hand shook, almost cutting her own finger.

She turned around—it was Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her calmly, then glanced at the chopped cabbage on the cutting board, showing an indescribable expression, "You're only cutting vegetables?"

Liang Shi: "...Ah, no."

Only then did she look down at the cutting board. She had originally planned to stir-fry cabbage to clear the oil from her stomach, but accidentally chopped the vegetables like this. It seemed they could only be used to make dumplings.

It had been a long time since she'd eaten dumplings anyway. After a two-second silence, Liang Shi said, "Right, I'm making dumplings. I... I haven't had time to cut the meat yet."

"Where's the meat?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "...In the refrigerator."

The atmosphere in the kitchen instantly became weird.

Liang Shi felt like she had thorns on her back. She coughed lightly to cover her embarrassment, "I just had a sudden craving for dumplings. Do you... do you want some?"

"I... I'll have some." Xu Qingzhu mimicked her way of speaking, then teased her after finishing, "What's wrong with you? Does drinking alcohol make you stutter?"

"I... I don't." After Liang Shi finished speaking, she coughed once, embarrassedly closing her eyes. Her whole ears were red, like the red clouds in the evening sky, "Don't... don't talk nonsense."

"I... how am I?" Xu Qingzhu took a bottle of yogurt from the refrigerator, tried to twist it open several times but couldn't, so she went around to Liang Shi's side and handed her the yogurt, "Open this, thank you."

Liang Shi took it smoothly, opened it and handed it back, only glancing at her once before quickly looking away.

Should she ask after all?

But it's so embarrassing.

But not asking felt like there was a thorn stuck in her heart. The psychological preparation and decision she had made this morning to lightly brush this matter aside crumbled like a collapsing building when she saw Xu Qingzhu.

She wanted to ask.

Most importantly, she wanted to know.

Xu Qingzhu was drinking yogurt beside her. After gulping down a mouthful, she asked, "Need help?"

Liang Shi answered crisply, "No need."

But after saying it, she regretted it, "Actually, maybe help a little?"

## Chapter 33 Part 4

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Practice proved that Xu Qingzhu was indeed, as Xu Qingya had said, a kitchen disaster.

When asked to add salt, she could add sugar instead. When asked to pour light soy sauce, she directly poured vinegar.

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Liang Shi regretted it and really wanted to take back her earlier words about letting her help.

"I think the office suits you better, don't you think?" Liang Shi asked this question when Xu Qingzhu mistook pepper powder for five-spice powder and poured it into the dumpling filling.

Xu Qingzhu coughed lightly, "I think so too."

"Then why don't you go back to the study to work? I'll call you when I'm done cooking." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "That doesn't seem right, does it?"

"If you move around here any more, we won't be able to eat dumplings today." Liang Shi said, "We'll both have to go hungry."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"But when did you learn to make dumplings?" Xu Qingzhu suddenly leaned closer, making Liang Shi's breathing irregular.

The memory fragments from last night came crashing down like a landslide, making her heart almost jump out of her chest.

"Just before." Liang Shi said, "I don't remember either. I hit my head before and forgot."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her intently, "But you told me then that you didn't have amnesia."

"I do still remember that you're my wife, but I've forgotten some things." Liang Shi argued, "If you don't believe me, ask Zhao Xuning. When I first woke up, you were very emotional too, so I couldn't tell you."

"So you could tell Zhao Xuning?" Xu Qingzhu's tone was casual, but her speech was fast, carrying a sense of urgency.

Liang Shi unconsciously followed her emotions, "She was my attending physician, so of course she would know."

"You say you remember I'm your wife. What else do you remember?" Xu Qingzhu continued asking.

"I still remember my brothers, my parents and sister." Liang Shi said, "I remember most people, but I've forgotten some of the things that happened."

Afraid she might drag her to get her brain examined again, Liang Shi immediately said, "Zhao Xuning has already done a complete checkup on me. There are no blood clots in my brain, and nothing's wrong with my body. Maybe I just... think I was too much of a bastard before, so I don't want to remember anymore?"

The latter half was said with little confidence.

Xu Qingzhu continued, "Then how do you know you were such a bastard before?"

"Well... I still have a little bit of memory." Liang Shi was already panicking inside. She had drunk too much last night, and when she woke up this morning, her mind was full of unhealthy thoughts that would affect normal thinking. Now being interrogated by Xu Qingzhu, her mouth was faster than her brain. She was also reflecting on whether she had said something she shouldn't have when she was drunk last night, causing Xu Qingzhu to become suspicious again and start a new round of testing on her.

No.

This was already direct interrogation.

Liang Shi swallowed and pushed her away a little, but Xu Qingzhu's cold and sharp gaze was still staring at her. Liang Shi said softly, "I remember a little. I was very bad to you before, but since I married you, I must have liked you... right?"

"So uncertain?" Xu Qingzhu approached her again, her gaze burning, "Should I help you remember?"

"No... no need." Liang Shi's hand pressed against the cutting board, and she was forced to retreat step by step, already pressed tightly against the kitchen counter, "When it's time to remember, I'll naturally remember. Isn't it... quite good the way we are now... just give me... give me another chance."

Liang Shi almost bit her tongue off.

What exactly did she say when she was drunk last night?

Why was Xu Qingzhu interrogating her so directly?

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi asked guiltily, "Are you... are you still going to eat?"

Liang Shi was stammering so much she was almost becoming a stutterer.

"We can talk about eating later." Xu Qingzhu stared at her, "Let's first discuss this matter of giving you a chance."

Liang Shi: "...What chance?"

"Already forgot what you just said?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "..."

She pushed Xu Qingzhu again, "Stay away from me when you talk."

This would help her think.

"No." Xu Qingzhu moved even closer to her, her tone rising with a hint of ambiguity, "Let's discuss it like this. Didn't you like it very much last night?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

Sure enough, she did do something to her last night?

Liang Shi's expression immediately collapsed. She bit her lip and sincerely apologized, "I'm sorry."

"What did you do? Why are you apologizing?" Xu Qingzhu used words to confuse her.

Liang Shi had already surrendered in her heart, looking dejected as if accepting whatever punishment was coming, "No matter what I did, I'm sorry."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

If Liang Shi had dared to stare at Xu Qingzhu at this moment, she would definitely have seen the corner of her mouth twitch upward.

She almost couldn't hold back her laughter.

But she still spoke in her cool, cold voice, "If you really feel sorry, then don't lie to me."

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

"Also, I've saved you twice before." Xu Qingzhu said, "You owe me two favors. I haven't asked you to repay them, and I've never lied to you, so can you be honest with me?"

"Then... then you..." Liang Shi struggled to express herself, but was somewhat embarrassed to speak. Finally, she stammered out the complete question, "Then can you tell me what happened between us last night?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, "You tell me first, then I'll tell you. Neither of us is allowed to lie. Whoever lies is a puppy."

Xu Qingzhu extended her pinky finger toward her, wanting to make a pinky promise.

Liang Shi felt like she was a kite—although flying freely in the sky, the string was held in Xu Qingzhu's hands.

She didn't know from which moment she had lost the initiative.

Probably from the moment she felt guilty.

Liang Shi: "..."

She made a pinky promise with Xu Qingzhu, but even touching her pinky finger was done quickly, then she pulled back.

She didn't dare linger.

## Chapter 33 Part 5

Xu Qingzhu smiled wryly but still put on a stern face and said, "Then let me ask you, do you still remember why you originally wanted to marry me?"

Liang Shi: "...I don't remember."

"Do you still remember what you did on our wedding night?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Her expression changed slightly.

She didn't have memories of that night, but she knew what the original had done that night.

She went to sleep with another woman.

"No lying." Xu Qingzhu reminded her.

Liang Shi closed her eyes and finally chose to be honest, "I roughly know."

Xu Qingzhu frowned, "What do you mean?"

"You mentioned it when you were drunk last time." Liang Shi brought it up somewhat embarrassedly, "Anyway, it was a very bastardly thing to do."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Do you still remember being kidnapped when you were seven?" Xu Qingzhu stared at her intently, observing her every expression.

Liang Shi was confused. She shook her head, "I don't remember."

"Then what's your catchphrase?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "...Eat well?"

Xu Qingzhu's expression cracked for a moment.

She made a last-ditch effort, saying expressionlessly, "Life will definitely get better, because we will surely have lots of love. Do you often say this too?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Occasionally."

Xu Qingzhu asked, "Why do you say it?"

Liang Shi: "...Just to encourage myself, I guess. Sometimes I feel like life is difficult, so I tell myself some things to help myself reconcile with the world."

Even though it was somewhat difficult to answer, Liang Shi still chose the most concise words and most appropriate language to explain to her.

"Besides, there's this line in a movie." Liang Shi said, "《Lonely Island》<sup>1</sup>. I occasionally think of this phrase after watching this movie."

"How old were you when you watched this movie?" Xu Qingzhu asked again.

Liang Shi: "Ten years old."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She suddenly showed a weary smile, making Liang Shi feel at a loss, "What's wrong? Is there something wrong with that phrase?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu said, "I was mistaken."

She pressed her lips together, her tone unable to hide her disappointment, "Sorry, you go ahead with your work. I'll go to the study."

"You haven't told me yet." Liang Shi asked her retreating figure, "What exactly happened between us last night?"

Xu Qingzhu stopped in her tracks, turned back with a smile, "You bit my finger."

Liang Shi: "?"

"You almost ate my fingernail." Xu Qingzhu said, "Sister, promise me, if you can't drink, don't brag, okay?"

Liang Shi: "...I didn't."

"Okay, got it." Xu Qingzhu waved her finger that had been trimmed bare, "Thanks to you, I'm planning to get a manicure today."

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

After Xu Qingzhu left the kitchen, Liang Shi knocked her head against the wall and began to regret drinking last night.

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The study was bathed in sunlight—today was another rare sunny day in Hazhou City.

After Xu Qingzhu closed the study door, she leaned against it to rest. She had asked each of those questions with trepidation.

Afraid it was her, yet afraid it wasn't her.

But in the end, she couldn't verify anything.

The latter possibility even seemed more likely.

She stayed in the study and watched the movie 《Lonely Island》 that Liang Shi had mentioned. It told the story of a goddess's daughter and a mermaid.



The mermaid never believed in gods, while the goddess's daughter initially didn't know her true identity and lived as a tragic human being with no family, no friends, wearing tattered clothes all day and going hungry.

But she was always optimistic and strong. She would say: Life will definitely get better, because we will have lots of love.

Yet her reality was that everyone despised her, no one liked her, and no one loved her.

Even when life was a complete mess, she still believed this firmly.

At the end of the film, she said: I've always believed in gods because if I didn't believe this way, I couldn't survive.

——Later I discovered that there really are gods in this world, and she will return the love I've lost to me.

It was quite a tear-jerking film.

Xu Qingzhu was someone who couldn't easily get emotionally invested when watching movies. As someone in a film and TV drought, she usually only watched highly-rated productions, and very few could make her cry. Even when the comments were already scrolling: "Tears streaming down like a river, crying so hard my hands are shaking."

She still had no reaction.

She had once watched a tear-jerker with Xu Qingya. Xu Qingya cried with snot and tears while she remained unmoved.

Xu Qingya said she was cold-blooded.

But this time, probably because it overlapped with her past memories, she couldn't stop crying halfway through the movie.

She almost integrated all her childhood memories into it.

By the time Liang Shi knocked on the door to call her for dinner, her eyes were still red.

When she opened the door, she startled Liang Shi, "What's wrong? It wasn't me who upset you, was it?"

Please, please let it not be.

Otherwise, the system would add misfortune points to her.

Xu Qingzhu said expressionlessly, "No, but it has something to do with you."

Liang Shi's heart immediately jumped to her throat.

"I watched the movie you mentioned earlier." Xu Qingzhu added.

Only then did Liang Shi relax, "I haven't rewatched it in a long time. That film is godlike in my heart."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, "Since when have you become so interested in movies?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She was silent for a long time, then used a phrase Xu Qingzhu had once said to retort, "Maybe you haven't really understood me either."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> 《孤島》 (Lonely Island) - This appears to be a fictional movie within the novel's universe that serves as a parallel to the main character's experiences.

## Chapter 33 Part 6

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Xu Qingzhu had to go out to meet clients in the afternoon, so Liang Shi stayed home alone.

Their department was actually working overtime too. She had an online meeting with Li Ran and Zhou Li to discuss the interview with Zhao Ying. The interview draft was handled by Li Ran, while Liang Shi helped her out, basically just checking for typos.

After Li Ran logged off, a little child appeared in Zhou Li's camera.

Rainbow greeted her, "Sister Liang Shi, do you have any other sci-fi movie recommendations? I'm in a drama drought."

Liang Shi: "..."

She still hadn't gotten used to Rainbow, this genius girl.

With such a childish face, speaking to her coolly as an equal.

Nevertheless, Liang Shi responsibly made her a list of films.

Rainbow was very polite, "Thank you, Sister Liang Shi."

Liang Shi said it was no problem.

After hanging up the video conference, Liang Shi had nothing else to do. Li Ran's article wasn't finished yet, so naturally it wasn't her turn to proofread.

With nothing better to do, she rewatched 《Lonely Island》 again.

In her memory, she had indeed watched this movie when she was ten years old.

But this movie was released when she was five.

Yet she had no memories from before age eight.

Very few people actually knew about this. Liang Shi never mentioned it to anyone. Apart from her grandparents, basically no one particularly close had appeared in her life.

Although her agent and assistant were very good to her, and she was generally well-liked wherever she went, she was used to being independent.

According to her grandparents, her parents died when she was eight years old.

When she was eight, she had a serious illness and then lost all her memories.

She didn't remember her parents, nor did she remember what she had experienced before age eight. But her grandparents were especially good to her. Even though the family was very poor, her grandparents would do their utmost to give her the best and provided her with much warmth.

When she was in elementary school, many people would ask about her parents, and she would say, "My parents went to a very distant place."

For a long time, Liang Shi was very sad.

She wasn't sad about not having parents or lacking parental love compared to others, but rather sad that she had lost all memories of her parents.

Her parents must be very heartbroken, right?

She had once told her grandmother this, but grandmother comforted her, "Your parents would be very happy to see you as you are now."

So she asked, "What was I like before?"

Grandmother smiled without speaking, stroking her head and saying, "You've always been the most well-behaved child."

Liang Shi was reminded of unpleasant memories, and halfway through watching, her heart felt heavy, so she turned off the movie.

In the evening, Liang Shi hastily ate a few bites of dinner and went to bed early after washing up, not even encountering Xu Qingzhu.

The next morning when she got up, she saw Xu Qingzhu.

And... Xu Qingzhu was in the kitchen.

Liang Shi immediately ran in, asking in surprise, "What are you doing?"

Xu Qingzhu answered calmly, "Making breakfast."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I decided to prove my cooking skills to you." Xu Qingzhu wore heat-resistant gloves, with steaming hot rice porridge cooking in the pot, "Although it's not a feast, I can still make simple meals."

Liang Shi: "Alright."

She just didn't know if it would be edible.

Liang Shi felt she might transform into a lab rat.

Xu Qingzhu ladled the rice porridge into bowls and brought them to the table before saying, "If my words yesterday caused you any harm, I apologize."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"I was too impulsive yesterday." Xu Qingzhu said, "I remembered some unpleasant things."

Liang Shi shook her head, "It's fine. Did something happen yesterday? I've forgotten."

"Are you a fish?" Xu Qingzhu teased, then let the matter drop.

Xu Qingzhu ate quietly. The rice porridge was sweet and barely edible.

After eating, Liang Shi washed the dishes.

She couldn't help but ask, "Did that phrase remind you of someone?"

Xu Qingzhu shrugged, "I thought of a very brave sister who also liked to say that phrase."

"So you suspected I was her?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "But I think that sister is probably dead."

Dead forever in her heart.

Yesterday has passed and cannot be retained.

She shouldn't have held onto hope.

Hearing this, Liang Shi could only offer comfort, "My condolences."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"By the way, I have friends coming this afternoon. Is that okay?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Is it Sally and Lin Luoxi?"

"There's them, plus my psychiatrist." Xu Qingzhu said, "She wants to see my living environment. It's a follow-up examination."

"That's fine. Do I need to avoid them?" Liang Shi asked.

"No need." Xu Qingzhu said, "Just pretend we don't exist."

Sally and Cherry were coming for work, and Dr. Gu wasn't just coming for her follow-up examination.

But Liang Shi didn't need to know that much.

As they were talking, the doorbell rang.

This house had never really had guests before, so the doorbell rarely rang. Its sudden ringing now surprised both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu, and they exchanged glances.

"Is it Sally and Lin Luoxi?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, "They were working on drawings until very late last night. They probably haven't gotten up yet."

While speaking, she went to open the door. After opening it, she saw a little girl with princess braids. Xu Qingzhu recognized her immediately, "Lingdang<sup>1</sup>?"

Lingdang was holding a panda plushie and bowed to greet her in a childish voice, "Hello, Aunt."

Xu Qingzhu smiled, "How did you suddenly come here? Did you come by yourself?"

"No, Mommy brought me." Lingdang pointed behind her, where a gentle woman was standing.

"Second sister-in-law." Xu Qingzhu greeted her, and the woman replied gently, "Sister-in-law, long time no see."

"Is Ah Shi here?" Second sister-in-law said, "I need to go back to my mother's house. Her father is on a business trip, and Lingdang insisted on coming to play at Aunt's house, so I could only bring her here. If you have time today, could you help look after Lingdang?"

Liang Shi came out of the kitchen, and Lingdang's eyes lit up as she called out, "Auntie, play games with me!"

Liang Shi hadn't expected such a pleasant surprise and immediately came over to hug Lingdang, "How did you come here?"

"Don't you welcome me?" Lingdang pouted.

"I'm overjoyed." Liang Shi hugged her and spun her around.

Standing to the side, Xu Qingzhu watched quietly.

Once again questioning life—since when did Liang Shi start enjoying playing with Lingdang?

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**Footnotes:** <sup>1</sup> Lingdang (铃铛) - literally means "little bell," a cute nickname for the child